Preaching, or JuD]. This was a small missionary order primarily dedicated to preaching the tenets of Ahl-e-Hadith Islam as interpreted by its founders. Soon after, the two joined forces.[5]

In 1986 Lashkar's parent organization Markaz al-Dawa wal-Irshad [Centre for Preaching and Guidance, or MDI] was formed to 'organize [Ahl-e-Hadith] Pakistanis participating in [the] Afghan Jihad on one Platform.'[6] But MDI was never intended to be simply another militant outfit. It had seventeen original founders who shared the aspiration of uniting the small Ahl-e-Hadith movement in Pakistan and promoting the purification of society, which it would rebuild based on their interpretation of Islam. Waging violent jihad was an essential part of this, but not the group's sole purpose. It was for this reason that Saeed was chosen to lead the nascent organization. Although Lakhvi had founded the first Pakistani Ahl-e-Hadith group to wage jihad against the Soviets, he was not a respected scholar. Saeed, on the other hand, was among the most influential of the Pakistani Ahl-e-Hadith ulema [scholars of Islamic law] involved in the Afghan jihad and was thus regarded as the best person to unite the Ahl-e-Hadith movement around MDI's objectives.[7]

The group had three functions: 'Jihad in the way of Allah preaching the true religion and the training of [a] new generation on Islamic lines.'[8] It regards jihad as waging war and sees doing so as obligatory for all Muslims until Islam emerges victorious against the unbelievers. This interpretation is at odds with that held by most Muslims, but in line with that of so-called 'jihadis,' a term that gained currency to connote those Sunni Muslims who share this extreme interpretation of jihad. The group places an equally strong emphasis on dawa, which literally means 'a call to God' and may include activities ranging from proselytizing to providing social services and charity. In this regard it stands out among major jihadi organizations, many of which rely primarily on violence and propaganda to achieve their objectives. MDI officially launched Lashkar as its military wing around 1990, after which the former was technically responsible for dawa and the latter for jihad.[9] However, as one former member explained, 'If you know their philosophy then you cannot differentiate between MDI and Lashkar.'[10] To avoid confusion this book refers to the group as Lashkar (or LeT) except in those instances where specific MDI activities are discussed.